

Retrofitting a commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system for reactive-metal grain growth

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High-temperature vacuum annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled grain growth but normally requires expensive turn-key vacuum induction furnaces. We describe an open, generator-agnostic modernization stack that converts a bare commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated, pyrometer-feedback annealing system. The contribution is the reproducible control/sensing/vacuum layer — LabVIEW/DAQ analog power control, dual-wavelength optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and an in-house machined graphite crucible/susceptor — which transfers between induction generators provided the generator exposes a monotonic analog power-control input. The reproducible build is anchored on the lab’s current, USA-sourced generator (CEIA “Power Cube” 6kW, procured through East Coast Induction); a ~1970 LEPEL high-frequency furnace served as the originating prototype. We report the system design, construction and operating procedures, and a performance validation grounded in ~100 archived anneal logs: a fixed-geometry power–temperature calibration ($R^2 = 0.991$ over 1200–1400 °C), repeatable 1200 °C / 12 h Ni4N5 processing (1201.2 ± 1.3 °C across 8 runs), stable long-duration control up to 40 h at 1325 °C, and SEM/EBSD/optical microstructural characterization of annealed reactive-metal specimens cross-referenced to their logged thermal histories. A tantalum-susceptor variant of the same charge stack extends the furnace to non-coupling ceramics at 2000–2350 °C, demonstrated with YSZ grain growth and an empirical high-temperature material-compatibility map. Complete design files, a costed bill of materials, control software, and the full run-log and characterization archives are openly available.

Keywords: induction furnace; grain growth; vacuum annealing; LabVIEW; pyrometer; open-source hardware

Status: working draft generated from the repository’s design files, standard operating procedure, parts list, schematics, and run logs, retargeted from HardwareX to *Review of Scientific Instruments* (REVTeX 4.2, `aip,rsi`). **[TODO:]**-marked items flag values or figures that still need to be confirmed or added before submission; outstanding bill-of-materials corrections from co-author review are tracked in the pull request and in the supplementary bill of materials.

I. INTRODUCTION

High-temperature annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled **grain growth**, which is central to studying microstructure–property relationships in metals such as nickel and iron^{1–3}. Doing this without oxidizing the sample requires both high temperature (~1400–1500 °C) and high vacuum (or inert atmosphere)^{4,5}. Commercial vacuum induction annealing furnaces that meet these requirements are expensive turn-key systems, which puts them out of reach for many academic labs.

This work takes the opposite approach: rather than building or buying a complete furnace, we **retrofit and modernize a bare RF induction generator** into a full annealing system by adding (1) computer power control, (2) closed-loop optical temperature control, (3) a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and (4) a machined graphite crucible/susceptor. The emphasis of the contribution is the **modernization stack itself**, which is deliberately **generator-agnostic**: the same

control software, vacuum chamber, pyrometer feedback, crucible, and work-coil geometry transfer from one induction generator to another. The only requirement a reader’s generator must satisfy is an **analog power-control input with a monotonic command→power response** over the usable range (e.g. 4–20 mA, 0–5 V, or 0–5 mA); near-linearity is convenient but not required, because the pyrometer feedback and PID calibration absorb any nonlinearity. That portability is the reproducible result and is what makes the design reusable by other labs that already own, or can buy, such an induction generator.

A second feature that broadens the system’s applicability is the **machined graphite crucible/susceptor**: because graphite couples strongly to the RF field and heats the charge indirectly by conduction and radiation, the furnace is not limited to electrically conductive samples — it can also process poorly- or non-coupling materials such as YSZ ceramic. This makes the same build useful well beyond reactive-metal annealing.

The modernization was first prototyped on a ~1970 LEPEL high-frequency induction furnace owned by the BYU Mechanical Engineering department — at the time the only departmental machine able to reach the Ni/Fe melting range. A “remote control” capability was added in August 2019 to drive the generator’s power from a computer instead of the front-panel knob. The lab subsequently moved the same stack onto a current, USA-

sourced solid-state generator (CEIA “Power Cube” 6kW via East Coast Induction), whose Power Controller C-V3 Plus accepts a standard analog (4–20 mA) power setpoint. An intermediate, separately-purchased import generator (CYSI GP-15A) was evaluated but did not meet the lab’s control requirements — the required analog remote-control input was lost across vendor model substitutions — and was retired. The reproducible build documented here therefore targets the current USA generator, with the LEPEL retrofit retained as historical context.

Compared with commercial vacuum annealing furnaces, this approach has **substantially lower capital cost** (the generator + heating head + controller + chiller package was quoted at $\approx$ \$16.5k in 2021, and the retrofit components are itemized in the supplementary bill of materials, versus \$50k–\$200k+ for turn-key systems), is repairable and modifiable by the user, and is broadly reusable: any lab with an induction generator and an analog power input can reproduce the control, vacuum, and temperature-sensing additions described below. The system is aimed at:

- materials labs needing **oxidation-free grain-growth anneals** of reactive metals (Ni, Fe) near their melting points;
- labs that own a **bare induction generator** and want to add computer setpoint control, optical feedback, and vacuum integration without buying a turn-key furnace;
- groups processing **poorly- or non-coupling charges** (e.g. YSZ ceramic) that can be heated indirectly through the graphite susceptor; and
- teaching/maker contexts wanting a **repairable, modifiable** high-temperature vacuum furnace built from documented, open design files.

All design files, control software, run logs, and characterization data are openly available: the development repository is <https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace> and an archival snapshot is deposited at Zenodo ([10.5281/zenodo.20878017](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20878017)), with hardware design files under the CERN-OHL-S v2 license and control code under the MIT license (proposed).

A. Scope and reproducibility boundary

To be explicit about what this paper does and does not reproduce: **this work does not reproduce the RF generator internals**. It reproduces the *modernization layer* built around a compatible generator — the computer power control, optical (pyrometer) feedback, high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, machined graphite crucible/susceptor, work-coil geometry, and the mechanical support fixturing. A reader supplies (or

already owns) a compatible generator and rebuilds the layer described here.

B. Prior art and comparison

Three classes of alternative exist, and each presents a limitation this design addresses. Commercial vacuum induction annealing furnaces are turn-key systems costing \$50k–\$200k+; they are closed, difficult to modify or repair in-house, and carry vendor lock-in. Openly documented resistively heated tube and box furnaces reach lower maximum temperatures with slower ramps than induction heating, and offer no RF-susceptor route to heating a non-coupling charge. Finally, induction generators themselves are widely available as bare industrial units (CEIA, Ambrell, and others), but ship without integrated vacuum, optical temperature feedback, or computer setpoint control — exactly the layer this work adds.

II. SYSTEM DESIGN AND DESCRIPTION

A. Architecture and control signal flow

The system comprises five subsystems, shown in the labeled overview schematic of Fig. 1; Fig. 6 shows the corresponding assembled system, with its main components labeled, at operating power:

1. **RF generator + work coil.** A solid-state induction generator (current build: CEIA Power Cube PW3-90/50) drives a water-cooled copper work coil. The coil carries both the oscillating current and cooling water. Coil geometry ($\sim$ 3in tall, 2.5in ID, $\sim$ 6.5 turns) was tuned to the sample/crucible stack⁶.
2. **Vacuum + gas.** A quartz tube forms the chamber and is connected through a KF40 flange and flexible bellows to an Edwards T-Station 85 turbomolecular pump ($\sim 1 \times 10^{-6}$ – 10^{-8} Torr). A manual vent valve and an inert-gas regulator/mass flow controller allow controlled venting and backfilling to suppress oxidation of reactive metals. The choice of atmosphere matters for graphite-crucible anneals: the best results were achieved by pumping the chamber to high vacuum and then backfilling with argon through the vent valve — purging the chamber with the inert gas before setting the mass flow controller to a steady trickle ($\sim$ 20 SCCM) for the anneal. Heating under vacuum alone instead tended to sublime graphite from the crucible onto the chamber walls. For the highest-temperature work, such as the temperatures needed for ceramic grain growth (Sec. V A), the chamber was evacuated and then continuously filled with

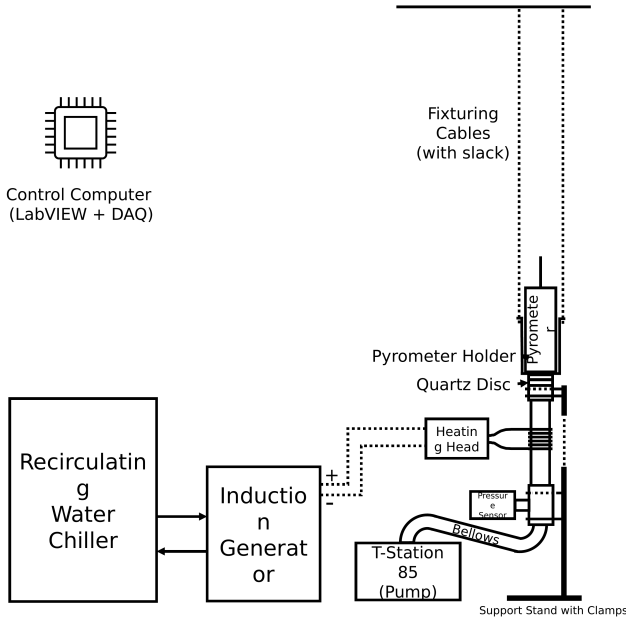


FIG. 1. System overview of the computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated induction annealing system: recirculating water chiller and induction generator drive a water-cooled heating head/work coil around a quartz-tube vacuum chamber; a dual-wavelength pyrometer sights the charge through a quartz optical disc; an Edwards T-Station 85 turbo-molecular pump (with pressure gauge and bellows) evacuates the chamber; and a control computer (LabVIEW + DAQ, top left) sets generator power and reads the pyrometer for closed-loop control.

argon while the turbopump was running, which helped avoid oxidation during heating.

3. **Optical temperature sensing.** A dual-wavelength (ratio) pyrometer (the canonical unit is a LumaSense IMPAC ISR 6, 800–2500 °C; the IMPAC brand is LumaSense’s) views the sample through a KF40 optical window, providing a non-contact temperature signal that is robust to emissivity changes and to the RF field that would corrupt thermocouples^{7–9}.
4. **Control / DAQ + LabVIEW.** A LabVIEW DAQ analog output sets generator power; the pyrometer signal is read back for closed-loop ramp/soak control. The VIs implement manual control, automated ramping, PID tuning, and email alerts. In the CEIA build the DAQ outputs 0–5 V to a **voltage-to-current loop conditioner** that converts the command to the controller’s 4–20 mA power-setpoint input (the LEPEL prototype instead took a 0–5 mA command directly). The closed-loop **signal flow** is therefore: **LabVIEW setpoint** → **DAQ analog output (0–5 V)** → **V→I conditioner (4–20 mA)** → **generator power** → **sample/crucible heating**

→ **pyrometer optical reading** → **DAQ analog input (scaled to °C)** → **PID controller** → **updated analog command**. The same path runs **open-loop** (direct command ramp) while the temperature is below the pyrometer’s ~700 °C detection floor; once the pyrometer reports a **sustained valid reading above that floor**, control hands over to **closed-loop PID** on the temperature¹⁰.

5. **Mechanical support + crucible.** A bolted support stand (8 short + 4 long sections, 12 corner braces, 4 floor mounts) carries the generator’s heating head, centering the work coil on the crucible position. The vacuum chamber itself has no support stand: the chamber stack is joined by KF40 flanges to the pyrometer housing, which is suspended from the ceiling by cables, so the vertical stack hangs from above. An **in-house machined graphite crucible** holds the sample and acts as the RF susceptor.

The LabVIEW control front panel (Fig. 2) exposes the ramp-up, PID-soak, and cool-down setpoint tables, the PID gains, the inert-gas flow control, and live power-command and pyrometer-temperature traces used to run and monitor an anneal.

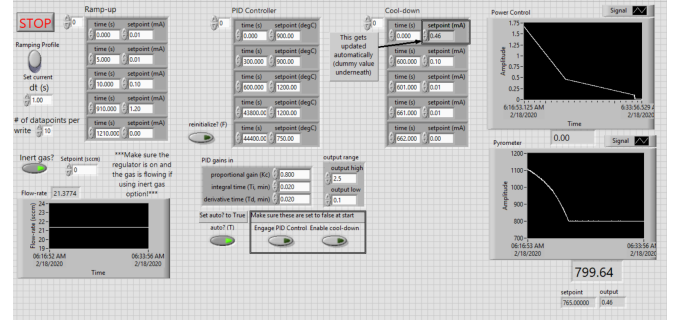


FIG. 2. LabVIEW control front panel: editable ramp-up / PID-soak / cool-down setpoint tables (time vs. analog command in mA below the pyrometer floor and vs. °C once closed-loop), PID gains and output range, inert-gas flow setpoint/readback, and live power-command and pyrometer-temperature strip charts. Here the pyrometer reads ~800 °C during ramp.

B. Technical specifications

As built, the documented system heats charges inside a 35 mm-ID fused-quartz tube at operating vacua of $\sim 1 \times 10^{-6}$ to 1×10^{-8} Torr, with temperature measured by the dual-wavelength ratio pyrometer over its ~800–2500 °C detection range (no reading below ~700 °C). Directly coupled metal charges in the machined graphite crucible reach the Ni/Fe grain-growth range (~1400–1500 °C), with demonstrated soaks from minutes up to

~40 h in the archived run logs; exchanging the graphite stack for the tantalum-susceptor ceramic configuration extends the working range to ~2000–2350 °C (Sec. V A). Power is commanded through a 4–20 mA analog setpoint via the LabVIEW/DAQ output and V→I conditioner (the LEPEL prototype instead took 0–5 mA directly), and the water-cooled copper work coil measures ~3 in tall, 2.5 in ID, with ~6.5 turns. These are *build-dependent* values: a reader supplies their own generator, pump, and pyrometer and re-establishes the corresponding values for their build.

C. Generator compatibility and portability

The control/sensing/vacuum layer transfers to any generator that meets these criteria:

- Exposes an **external analog power-control input** (e.g. 4–20 mA or 0–5 V/0–5 mA).
- The command→delivered-power response is **monotonic over the usable range** (near-linear is convenient but not required, since the pyrometer feedback closes the loop).
- Supports a **water-cooled induction head/coil** matching the documented coil dimensions.
- Delivers **enough RF power** to reach the target temperature for the documented crucible/sample stack.
- Allows **safe electrical isolation** between the DAQ/control path and the generator input.
- Has the required cooling and line power for the selected generator.

When porting to a new generator, the following must be re-established: analog-command scaling, power-to-temperature calibration, PID gains, coil/sample alignment, maximum safe ramp rate, and any generator-specific interlock behavior. The port from the ~1970 LEPEL prototype to the current CEIA build is the existence proof for this portability claim: the dual-wavelength pyrometer feedback, the quartz-tube/KF40 vacuum chamber, the machined graphite crucible/susceptor, the bolted support stand, and the LabVIEW/DAQ control VIs all transferred unchanged. Only the analog interface itself differed — the LEPEL took a 0–5 mA command directly, whereas the CEIA Power Controller C-V3 Plus expects 4–20 mA, hence the V→I loop conditioner — and the power-temperature calibration and PID gains were re-established for the new generator, as they must be for any port. The generator’s internal operating frequency (~200–450 kHz vacuum-tube LEPEL vs. the solid-state CEIA’s self-set frequency) and maximum power (~35 kW vs. 6 kW) sit behind the analog interface and required no change to the stack beyond re-tuning power for the charge.

D. Custom-machined graphite crucible / susceptor

Because some charges of interest couple poorly to the RF field (e.g. YSZ ceramic) or must be physically contained, the sample is held in a **graphite crucible machined in-house from 3000 °C-grade graphite stock** (Cotronics 56L-3). The graphite couples strongly to the induction field and acts as a **susceptor**, transferring heat to the contained charge by conduction/radiation; this makes the same furnace usable for conductive metals (direct coupling) and for non/poorly-coupling materials (indirect, susceptor-driven heating). Crucibles are machined to fit inside the quartz tube and seat on a ceramic-cylinder / Teflon spacer stack. Cracked crucibles are repaired with a 3000 °C graphite cement (Resbond 931) rather than discarded. The two-piece geometry — a cup body and a lidded cap with a central bore — contains the charge while leaving an optical path for the pyrometer to sight the sample (Fig. 3). The measured dimensions of every piece in the stack (crucible body, lid, alumina spacer discs, and sapphire pyrometer window) are given in Fig. 4; fully assembled, the crucible stack stands 13 mm tall. The specimen-loading sequence — specimen sandwiched between two alumina sheets in the cup body, lid seated on top, and sapphire window placed over the lid bore — is shown step by step in Fig. 5. For ceramic charges requiring soak temperatures beyond the graphite/alumina stack’s service range, the crucible stack is exchanged for a tantalum-susceptor variant described in Sec. V A.



FIG. 3. Fully disassembled graphite crucible. Top left is the crucible lid, top middle is the bottom of the crucible that acts as the specimen carrier, far right is the sapphire window, bottom left and middle are the alumina sample-surrounding sheets.

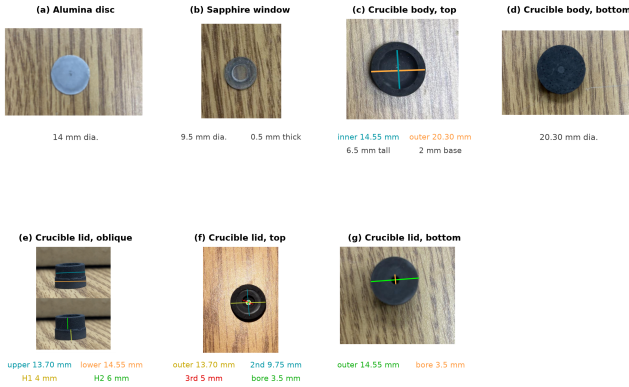


FIG. 4. Measured dimensions of each part of the graphite crucible/susceptor stack, with the coloured measurement lines drawn on the corresponding photograph. (a) Alumina spacer disc, 14 mm dia. (b) Sapphire pyrometer window, 9.5 mm dia., 0.5 mm thick. (c) Crucible body, top: machined sample cavity 14.55 mm ID (teal), 20.30 mm OD (orange); the cup is 6.5 mm tall with a 2 mm base. (d) Crucible body, bottom face, 20.30 mm dia. (e) Crucible lid, oblique: the stepped plug seats into the cavity — 13.70 mm upper step (teal), 14.55 mm lower shoulder (orange); the upper step is 4 mm tall (H1, yellow) and the lower shoulder 6 mm tall (H2, green). (f) Crucible lid, top: four concentric steps of 13.70 mm (outermost), 9.75 mm, 5 mm, and a 3.5 mm central pyrometer-sighting bore. (g) Crucible lid, bottom: 14.55 mm seating face (green) and the 3.5 mm through-bore (orange). Two alumina discs sandwich the specimen inside the cavity, the lid seats on top, and the sapphire window closes the bore so the pyrometer sights the sample through the lid; fully assembled the stack stands 13 mm tall.

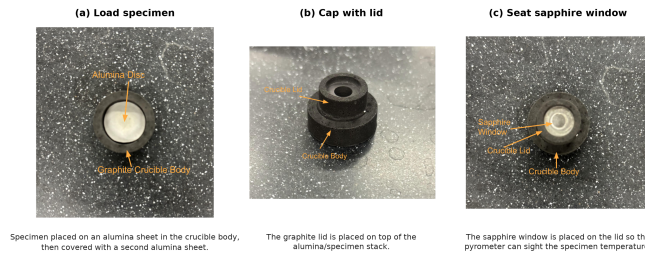


FIG. 5. Specimen-loading sequence for the graphite crucible/susceptor, in order (orange call-outs name the visible parts). (a) The specimen is placed on an alumina sheet in the crucible body and covered with a second alumina sheet, so the alumina discs isolate the specimen from the graphite. (b) The graphite lid is seated on top of the alumina/specimen stack. (c) The sapphire window is placed over the lid bore, closing the crucible while leaving an optical path for the pyrometer to sight the specimen temperature through the window.

III. CONSTRUCTION AND OPERATION

A. System assembly

This section describes how the subsystems of Fig. 1 are physically connected, following the heating, vacuum, gas, and control paths in turn; the costed

part list and the design-file inventory (coil drawing, editable schematics, STEP models) are maintained as supplementary material. Figure 6 shows the assembled system at operating power, and Fig. 8 details the vacuum and gas-handling connections described below.

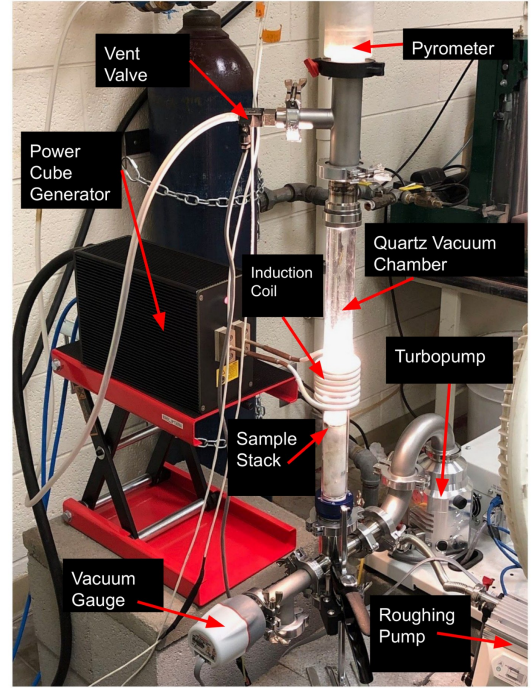


FIG. 6. The fully assembled, functioning furnace with the main components labeled. The Power Cube generator (left) drives the water-cooled induction coil around the vertical quartz vacuum chamber, which glows at the sample-stack position; the pyrometer sights down the chamber axis from the top of the stack; the vent valve admits the argon backfill; and the wide-range vacuum gauge, turbopump, and separately supported roughing pump complete the vacuum path at the bottom of the stack.

a. Heating path. The generator's heating head, carrying the water-cooled copper work coil (~ 3 in tall, 2.5 in ID, ~ 6.5 turns; Fig. 7), mounts on an adjustable platform on the bolted support stand (8 short + 4 long sections, 12 corner braces, 4 floor mounts) so the coil can be centered on the crucible position of the vertically suspended quartz tube. The recirculating chiller supplies cooling water to the generator and coil, which carry both the RF current and the coolant. Inside the tube, the machined graphite crucible/susceptor (Figs. 3–5), machined from 3000 °C graphite stock and repaired with graphite cement when cracked, seats at coil height on a ceramic-cylinder/Teflon spacer stack; the pyrometer, mounted in its housing at the top of the chamber stack, sights the specimen through the optical window and the sapphire disc in the crucible lid.

b. Vacuum path. The chamber is the fused-quartz tube itself. Its open end terminates in a KF40 flange whose optical window — a 55 mm quartz disc seated on

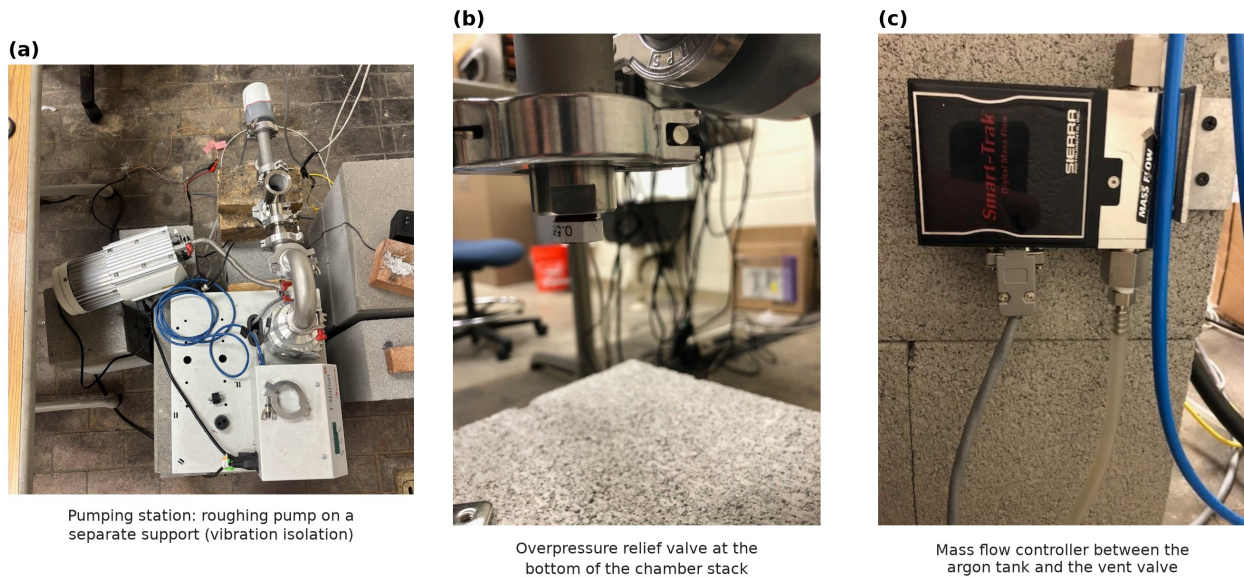


FIG. 8. Vacuum and gas-handling details of the assembled system. (a) Turbo pumping station with the roughing pump mounted on a separate support, coupled to the pumping station only through a flexible hose, so pump vibration is not transmitted into the chamber. (b) Overpressure relief valve (0.5 psi cracking pressure) at the bottom of the vacuum chamber stack. (c) Digital mass flow controller (Sierra Smart-Trak) connecting the argon tank to the vent valve for controlled venting and inert backfill.

evacuated quartz tube poses a fracture/implosion risk — operators wear safety glasses — and venting against a spinning turbo pump can destroy the pump, so the turbo must spin down fully before the vent valve opens. Because the coil and chiller run water immediately next to energized hardware, flow is confirmed and leaks are checked before RF is applied, and water lines are routed away from electronics. A melted-through specimen or hot graphite oxidizing on a premature vent can contaminate the pump line and burn the operator, so samples cool under vacuum and vacuum components are handled with clean nitrile gloves. Inert-gas backfilling in an enclosed space is an asphyxiation risk and is done only with adequate ventilation. Finally, the RF near-field can corrupt or damage nearby instruments, which are shielded and kept clear of the coil.

IV. PERFORMANCE VALIDATION

The archive contains 100+ logged runs (IFrun001–100) across Ni200, Ni4N5, YSZ, and Pd thermal-evaporation experiments, with temperatures of ~ 900 – 1400 °C and soak durations from minutes to ~ 40 h, each with raw spreadsheet/text/LabVIEW-measurement traces and some photos. Per-run traces were parsed into uniform CSV/PNG files, and the quantitative metrics below were computed reproducibly from those traces by scripts archived alongside the data (see Data Availability). Because the archive is a retrospective operating record rather than a prospectively balanced design of experiments, every comparison is restricted to an internally consistent subset (matching material,

nominal profile, and operating configuration) and the power–temperature relation is reported as an *operational* calibration for one fixed geometry, not as a universal transfer function.

a. Power-command $\rightarrow$ temperature calibration (Fig. 9). For one fixed Ni4N5/quartz/graphite/optical configuration, four archived steady-state anneals spanning 1200 – 1400 °C (IFrun039, IFrun040, IFrun038, IFrun032) give a monotonic relation between the soak-mean analog power command and the soak-mean pyrometer temperature. A linear guide-to-the-eye fit over these points is $T \approx 931 + 632I$ (°C, I in mA), $R^2 = 0.991$, $n = 4$. This is presented as an operational calibration only: the broader archive shows configuration-dependent offsets (e.g. runs near 1200 °C required soak-mean commands of ~ 0.44 mA vs. ~ 0.66 mA in a different era/geometry), so the fit must not be read as a universal command–temperature law.

b. Representative ramp/soak with control metrics (Fig. 10). Run IFrun079 (specimen Ni4N5_084, nominal 1300 °C / 12 h) is a representative closed-loop anneal. Measured against the 1300 °C setpoint, the soak held 1302.1 ± 3.0 °C (mean $\pm$ SD) over the 12 h plateau, with a 10–90 % rise time of ~ 1135 s, an overshoot of ~ 12 °C, a maximum in-soak deviation of ~ 10 °C, and a near-zero linear drift of -0.02 °C/h, demonstrating that the pyrometer-feedback loop holds a programmed soak over many hours.

c. Repeatability and long-soak stability (Figs. 11–12). Run-to-run repeatability was assessed on the most internally consistent cohort available: eight Ni4N5 anneals at a nominal 1200 °C / 12 h condition (IFrun052–IFrun060, excluding missing run numbers),

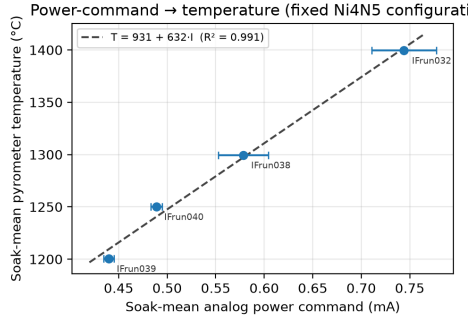


FIG. 9. Power-command $\rightarrow$ temperature calibration for one fixed archived Ni4N5 configuration. Points are soak-mean values; horizontal bars are the in-soak SD of the analog command. The dashed line is a guide-to-the-eye linear fit ($R^2 = 0.991$, $n = 4$).

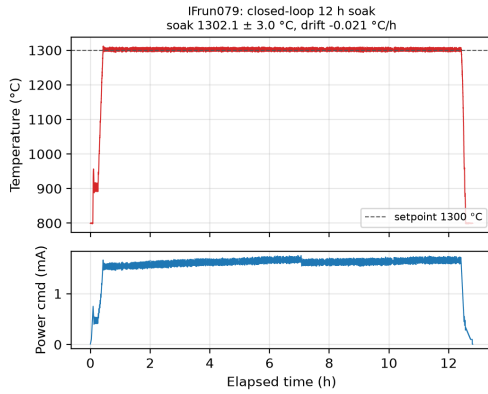


FIG. 10. Representative closed-loop anneal (IFrun079, Ni4N5, nominal 1300 °C / 12 h): pyrometer temperature with setpoint overlay (top) and analog power command (bottom). Soak mean 1302.1 ± 3.0 °C, drift -0.02 °C/h.

all logged under the same gas-flow configuration. Across these runs the soak temperature was 1201.2 ± 1.3 °C (range 1199.8–1204.2 °C; coefficient of variation 0.11 %; $n = 8$), peak temperature 1212.6 ± 6.7 °C, and soak duration 766 ± 15 min. Runs from other periods or geometries (e.g. IFrun016, IFrun019, IFrun049) are deliberately *not* pooled into this estimate. Long-duration stability was demonstrated with two Ni200 anneals at 1325 °C: a 20 h run (IFrun081) held 1326.5 ± 1.5 °C with drift -0.004 °C/h, and a 40 h run (IFrun080) maintained ~ 1326 – 1329 °C over 2400 min in-band.

V. MICROSTRUCTURAL VALIDATION

The furnace exists to change microstructure, so the key validation is **real microstructural data** tied to specific thermal histories. The archived SEM/EBSD and optical-microscopy datasets are keyed by Ni4N5_### / Ni200_### specimen IDs that map directly to the run IDs

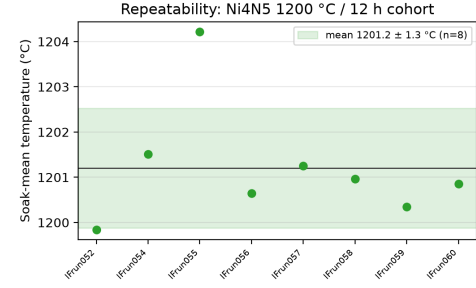


FIG. 11. Run-to-run repeatability of the Ni4N5 1200 °C / 12 h cohort (IFrun052–IFrun060, $n = 8$). Points are per-run soak-mean temperatures; the band is mean $\pm$ SD (1201.2 ± 1.3 °C).

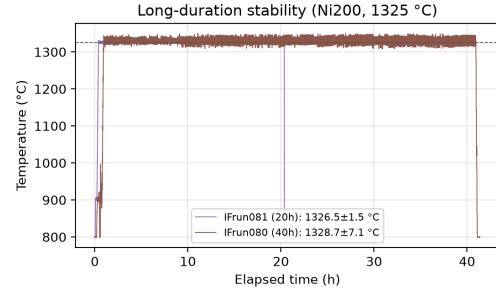


FIG. 12. Long-duration thermal stability: Ni200 anneals at 1325 °C held for 20 h (IFrun081) and 40 h (IFrun080).

of the anneal logs. This mapping is built reproducibly by a script that parses the specimen ID out of every characterization folder, joins it to the machine-parsed run summary, and writes a per-specimen cross-reference: **35 characterized specimens**, of which **9 link to a parsed run log**, **10 carry archived EBSD/OIM data**, and one carries EDS. Inverse-pole-figure (IPF) EBSD orientation maps of two annealed specimens (Fig. 13) resolve hundreds of indexed grains. Notably, the anneals leave surfaces that index well with no metallographic preparation. Fig. 14(a,b) shows a raw, as-collected Kikuchi pattern (electron backscatter pattern) recorded live from specimen Ni4N5_028 (annealed in IFrun043), with bands and zone axes crisply resolved even at coarse 8×8 detector binning, alongside the SEM live view of the thermally grooved grain boundaries that the accompanying EBSD line scans traverse. Nor were such patterns only viewed live: during EBSD mapping of two nickel specimens from the early commissioning campaign, the acquisition software archived the raw pattern at every scan point, and **more than 100,000 per-point raw patterns** survive (Fig. 14(c–e)), enabling re-indexing or pattern-quality re-analysis with modern indexing approaches without re-mounting the specimens. The thermal grooving that delineates the boundaries is itself a record of the anneal: edge-on views of specimen Ni4N5_053 (IFrun059, 1200 °C / 12 h), imaged after only an ultrasonic ethanol

clean, show deep grooves — the equilibrium of grain-boundary energy against surface energy at the soak temperature — and grain boundaries that frequently traverse the full sheet thickness, a step toward columnar through-thickness grain structures (Fig. 15). The best-correlated specimen, Ni4N5_081 (annealed in IFrun082 at a nominal 1300 °C for 20 h; logged soak $\sim$ 1301 °C), is documented across length scales — optical grain map with in-image grain-size measurements, SEM survey, and high-magnification grain-boundary detail (Fig. 16). The full multi-gigabyte raster/EBSD archive (including .oim, .osc, .ang, and DREAM.3D volumes) remains on the lab’s institutional share and is inventoried per file in the characterization catalogs distributed with the data. Grain size is quantified with: number of grains analyzed, equivalent-circle-diameter or intercept metric, median + IQR (or mean $\pm$ SD), segmentation/cleanup criteria, minimum-grain-area threshold, and whether twins are merged or separated, with the specimen/run (not the individual grain) treated as the experimental unit^{1,3}. Where as-received baselines are unavailable for a batch, results are framed as final-state comparisons across archived anneals rather than as fully parameterized grain-growth kinetics.

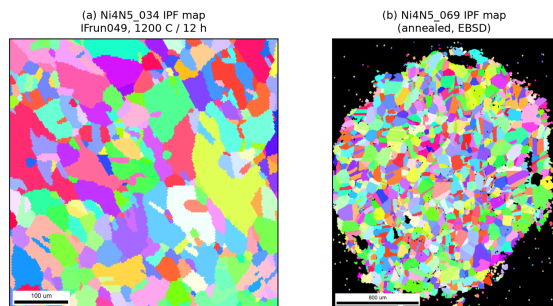


FIG. 13. EBSD inverse-pole-figure (IPF) orientation maps of two annealed Ni4N5 specimens, rendered from the archived EBSD scans. (a) Ni4N5_034 (IFrun049, 1200 °C / 12 h); (b) Ni4N5_069. Each indexed color is a crystallographic orientation; the maps resolve hundreds of grains for grain-size and texture analysis.

Controls that further isolate the instrument’s behavior — open-loop vs. closed-loop on the same target cycle, vacuum vs. inert-gas backfill mode, directly-coupled metal vs. susceptor-mediated ceramic heating, and multi-hour long-soak stability — are partially represented in the archive and are natural extensions for a prospective study.

a. Specimen $\leftrightarrow$ thermal-history linkage. Each specimen used in the thermal-performance and microstructural validation is tied to its exact run, and to its archived characterization data, in Table I. “Nominal soak” is the target parsed from the run filename; “logged soak T” is the machine-parsed soak-mean from the trace; “atmosphere” indicates whether active gas flow was present in the parsed log summary, not a

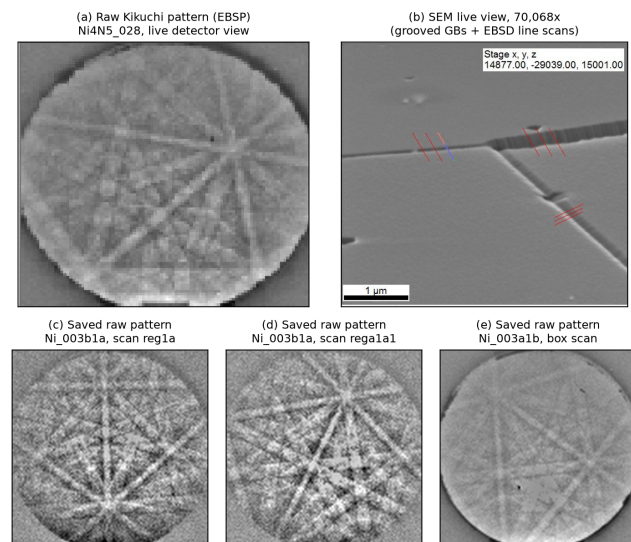


FIG. 14. Raw (as-collected) EBSD acquisitions from furnace-annealed nickel, with no metallographic preparation. (a) Raw Kikuchi pattern (electron backscatter pattern) of specimen Ni4N5_028 (annealed in IFrun043) as seen live on the detector at 8×8 binning (30 ms exposure), with Kikuchi bands and zone axes crisply resolved; (b) the corresponding SEM live view at 70,068 $\times$, where thermal grooving alone delineates the grain boundaries crossed by the EBSD line scans (red marks; 1 μ m scale bar). (c–e) Representative per-scan-point raw patterns (115 $\times$ 115 px at 8×8 binning) saved automatically during EBSD mapping of the early-campaign specimens Ni_003b1a and Ni_003a1b; more than 100,000 such patterns are archived. The pattern quality obtainable straight from the furnace reflects the low residual surface damage of the annealed condition.

fully reconstructed gas chemistry; the characterization column gives archived SEM/optical file counts and flags archived EBSD/OIM data. The complete 35-specimen cross-reference, including characterized specimens whose run logs are not in the parsed set, is distributed with the supplementary material; run IDs are abbreviated here.

A. Extension to ceramic charges: YSZ

The same control, vacuum, and sensing stack extends to charges that do not couple to the RF field at all, demonstrated with grain growth in yttria-stabilized zirconia (YSZ). Ceramic grain growth requires substantially higher soak temperatures ($\gtrsim$ 1700 °C, and usefully 2000–2500 °C) than the Ni anneals — beyond the service range of the alumina spacers (1787 °C rating) and too hot for the graphite lid/sapphire-window geometry of Fig. 5 — so only the charge stack inside the quartz tube is exchanged (Fig. 18(a)). The YSZ specimen is sandwiched between two tantalum blocks (25.5 mm diameter) that replace graphite as the susceptor at these temperatures; the pair seats in a ceramic crucible (MgO shown; boron

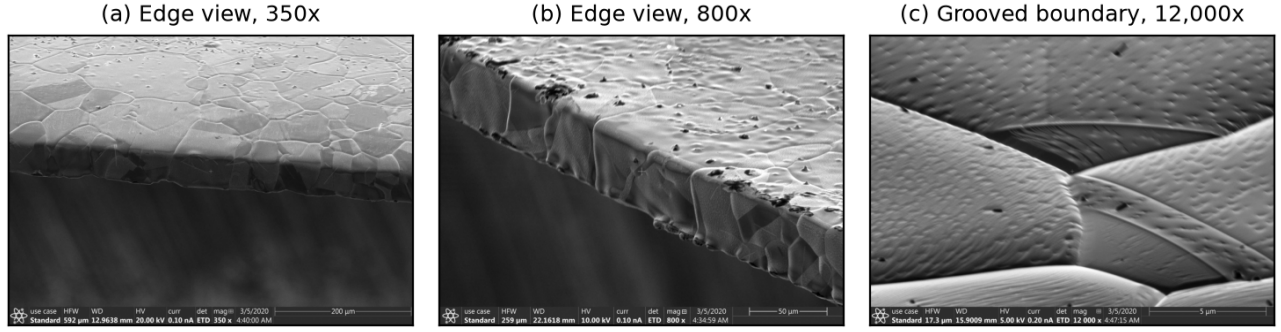


FIG. 15. Grain-boundary thermal grooving on specimen Ni4N5_053 after IFrun059 (1200 °C / 12 h), imaged edge-on in the as-annealed condition (ultrasonic ethanol clean only; no polishing). (a) Edge view at 350 $\times$ (200 μ m scale bar): several grain boundaries traverse the full sheet thickness. (b) Edge and top surface at 800 $\times$ (50 μ m scale bar), with grooves outlining the surface grain structure. (c) A single grooved boundary at 12,000 $\times$ (5 μ m scale bar): the deep trench develops as grain-boundary energy equilibrates against surface energy at the soak temperature.

Ni4N5_081 microstructure after IFrun082 (1300 °C / 20 h, flow)

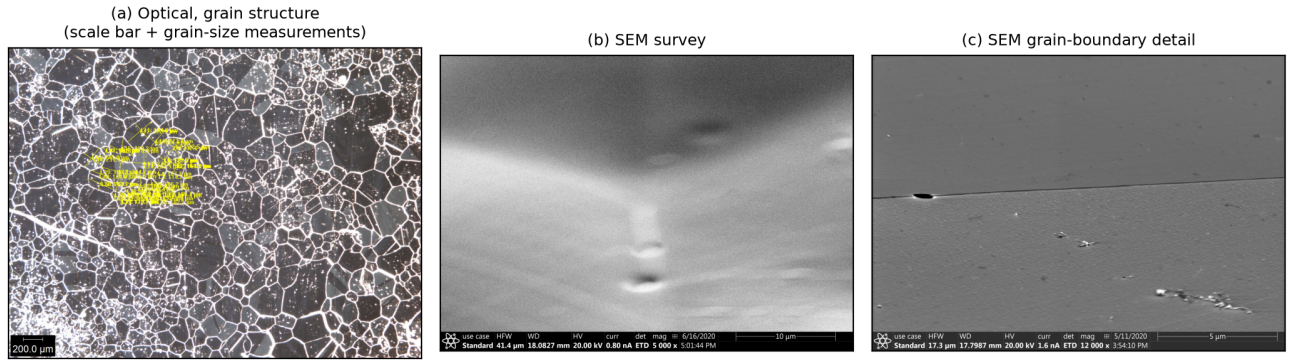


FIG. 16. Multi-scale microstructure of specimen Ni4N5_081 after IFrun082 (nominal 1300 °C / 20 h, gas flow), correlating the characterization archive with a single logged thermal history. (a) Optical micrograph (grain structure, 200 μ m scale bar, with in-image grain-size measurements); (b) SEM survey; (c) high-magnification SEM grain-boundary detail.

nitride was also used, see below) on an alumina support rod that raises the stack to coil height inside a fresh ~ 35 mm-ID quartz tube. The generator, vacuum path, gas handling, pyrometer, and LabVIEW control are untouched — the swap is a specimen-stack change, not a furnace change. For these high-temperature runs the chamber was first evacuated and then continuously filled with argon while the turbopump was running, which helped avoid oxidation during heating.

a. Tantalum-susceptor heat curve. Figure 17 quantifies the temperature range this stack opens up, from an archived lab workbook. With a single tantalum block the pyrometer reads ~ 1230 °C at a 10 % power command, rising monotonically to ~ 2020 °C at 31 %; stacking two blocks shifts the whole curve upward (~ 1790 °C at 10 %), sustains a ~ 2000 °C hold for over an hour at a constant 17 % command (Fig. 17(b)), and reaches **2344 °C at 33 %** before that ramp was terminated by the chamber pressure interlock — i.e., the practical ceiling encountered so far is set by outgassing

at temperature, not by available RF power. Since the dual-wavelength pyrometer reads to 2500 °C, the sensing chain covers the full demonstrated range.

b. High-temperature material compatibility. Operating between 2000 and 2500 °C makes chemical compatibility between the specimen, susceptor, and crucible the design constraint, and the archived configuration survey maps it empirically. Three stack variants were run, each seated in a boron nitride crucible resting on the alumina support rod: a tantalum susceptor block placed on top of the YSZ specimen at 2500 °C for 8 h (successful grain growth, but Ta vapor deposited on the YSZ); the YSZ specimen set into a graphite susceptor block at 2000 °C for 168 h (the YSZ reacted with the graphite and was consumed); and a Ta/YSZ/Ta double-block sandwich at 2130 °C for 80.4 h (a reaction shell formed around the tantalum, attributed to Ta–BN contact). The observed pairwise incompatibilities — alumina–graphite eutectic near 1800 °C; carbon consuming YSZ at 2000 °C; YSZ–Ta interdiffusion

TABLE I. Specimen $\leftrightarrow$ thermal-history linkage and committed characterization data for the runs used in the validation.

Specimen	Material	Run	Nominal soak	Logged soak T	Soak time	Atmos.	Characterization	Role / figure
Ni4N5_026	Ni4N5	IFrun039	1200 °C	1200.4 °C	6 h	no-flow	—	Calibration (Fig. 9)
Ni4N5_027	Ni4N5	IFrun040	1250 °C	1250.0 °C	6 h	no-flow	—	Calibration
Ni4N5_025	Ni4N5	IFrun038	1300 °C	1299.9 °C	1 h	no-flow	—	Calibration
Ni4N5_022	Ni4N5	IFrun032	1400 °C	1399.6 °C	10 min	no-flow	—	Calibration
Ni4N5_084	Ni4N5	IFrun079	1300 °C	1302.1 °C	12 h	flow	—	Representative (Fig. 10)
Ni4N5_040	Ni4N5	IFrun052	1200 °C	1199.8 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability (Fig. 11)
Ni4N5_042,044	Ni4N5	IFrun054	1200 °C	1201.5 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni4N5_045,046	Ni4N5	IFrun055	1200 °C	1204.2 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni4N5_047,048	Ni4N5	IFrun056	1200 °C	1200.6 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni4N5_049,050	Ni4N5	IFrun057	1200 °C	1201.2 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni4N5_051,052	Ni4N5	IFrun058	1200 °C	1201.0 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni4N5_053,054	Ni4N5	IFrun059	1200 °C	1200.3 °C	12 h	flow	4 SEM, 3 opt. (Ni4N5_053)	Repeatability; GB grooving (Fig. 15)
Ni4N5_056,057	Ni4N5	IFrun060	1200 °C	1200.9 °C	12 h	flow	—	Repeatability
Ni200_015	Ni200	IFrun081	1325 °C	1326.5 °C	20 h	flow	3 opt.	Long soak (Fig. 12)
Ni200_017	Ni200	IFrun080	1325 °C	1326.3 °C	40 h	flow	2 opt.	Long soak
Ni4N5_079,080	Ni4N5	IFrun072	1400 °C	—	12 h	flow	—	Process-window specimen
Ni4N5_034	Ni4N5	IFrun049	1200 °C	1200.0 °C	12 h	no-flow	4 SEM, EBSD	EBSD (Fig. 13)
Ni4N5_081	Ni4N5	IFrun082	1300 °C	1301.4 °C	20 h	flow	10 SEM, 10 opt., EBSD	Microstructure (Figs. 13–16)
Ni4N5_010	Ni4N5	IFrun016	1200 °C	1199.9 °C	—	no-flow	4 opt.	Characterization only
Ni4N5_012	Ni4N5	IFrun019	1200 °C	1199.6 °C	—	no-flow	1 opt.	Characterization only
Ni200_001	Ni200	IFrun004/005	—	—	—	no-flow	3 opt.	Characterization only
Ni4N5_001b	Ni4N5	IFrun006	—	—	—	no-flow	2 opt.	Characterization only

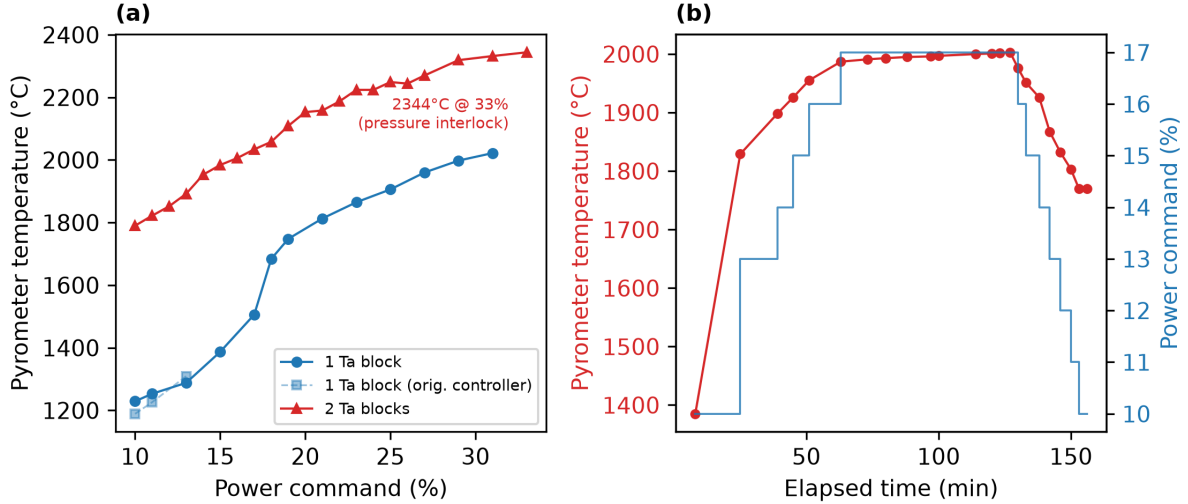


FIG. 17. Measured heat curves of the tantalum-susceptor (ceramic) stack. (a) Pyrometer temperature vs. generator power command for one and two stacked tantalum susceptor blocks (the faint series repeats the single-block measurement on the original power controller); the two-block ramp reached 2344 °C at a 33% command before the chamber pressure interlock ended the test. (b) Timed two-block ramp/soak: a constant 17% command holds ~ 2000 °C (2000 ± 3 °C over the final hour) before a stepped ramp-down.

and Ta deposition at 2500 °C; Ta–BN and Ta–MgO surface degradation; Ta carburizing to (still-functional) gold-colored TaC; and Ta gettering oxygen from any source — are recorded with photographs in the archived survey. Two practical rules emerged: shorter, hotter anneals stay clean (a $\sim 90 \mu\text{m}$ clean-grained YSZ specimen was produced in 45 min in the double-Ta configuration, while runs past ~ 3 h contaminated the specimen), and above ~ 2200 °C a carbon susceptor that does not touch the YSZ (e.g. graphite contained in a BN crucible) is the indicated configuration. Archived

optical micrographs (Fig. 18(b,c)) show the resulting equiaxed YSZ grain structures, including a specimen after a 1700 °C / 10 h anneal. [TODO: link the YSZ anneals to their IFrun IDs (which logged runs the heat curves and the 2500/2130/2000 °C configuration tests correspond to), and confirm which generator the tantalum heat curves were recorded on.]

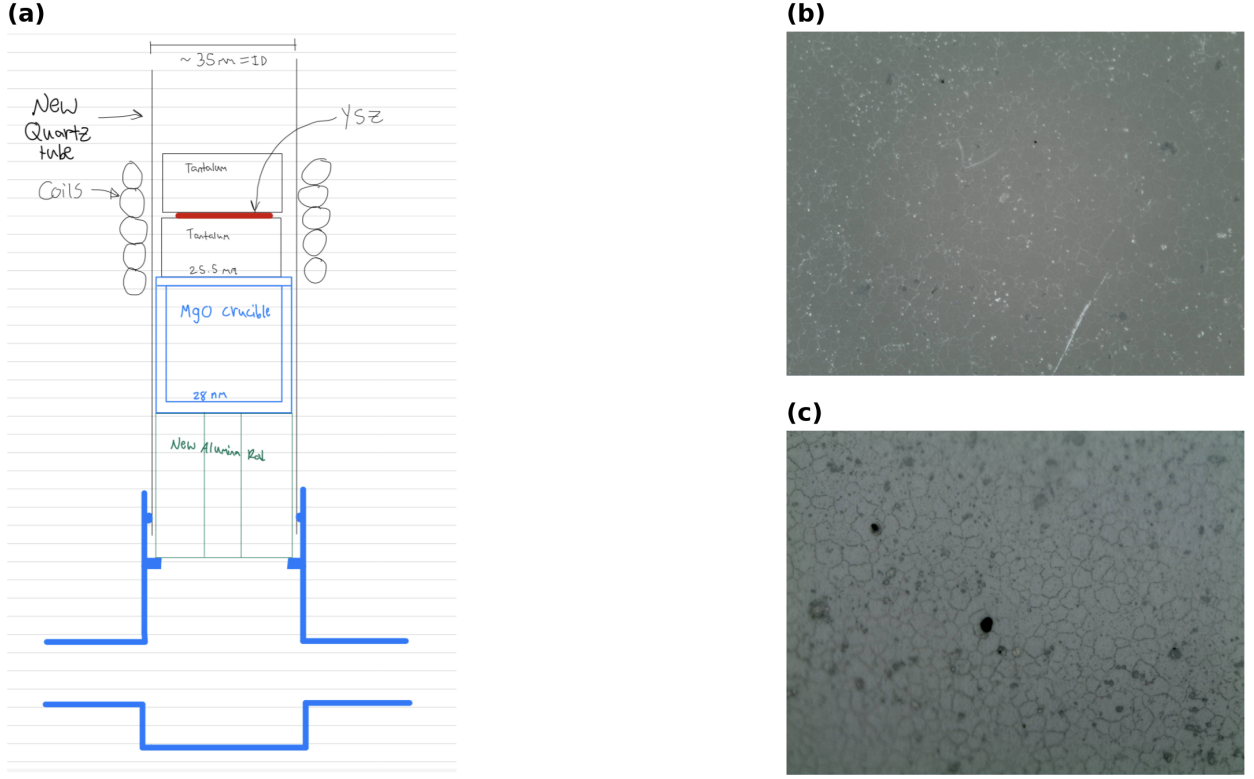


FIG. 18. High-temperature ceramic (YSZ) configuration and resulting microstructure. (a) Charge-stack schematic: inside a fresh ~ 35 mm-ID quartz tube, the YSZ specimen (red) is sandwiched between two 25.5 mm tantalum susceptor blocks, seated in a 28 mm MgO crucible on an alumina support rod that raises the stack to coil height; the coil, vacuum, pyrometer, and control paths are unchanged from the metal configuration. (b) Optical micrograph of YSZ after a 1700°C / 10 h anneal. (c) Optical micrograph of an induction-annealed YSZ specimen, showing the equiaxed grain structure.

B. Limitations of the retrospective validation

The validation dataset is retrospective rather than prospectively designed, so the archived runs are not treated as a balanced factorial experiment and comparisons are restricted to internally consistent subsets. Because induction coupling, radiative view factors, and pyrometer line-of-sight depend on specimen/crucible geometry and optical alignment, the power-command/temperature calibration is reported only for a fixed archived configuration and is not a universal transfer function. Reported temperatures are closed-loop ratio-pyrometer readings in a fixed optical geometry; absolute specimen temperature may still depend on emissivity and surface condition not fully reconstructable for every archived run^{7,8}. Run-to-run repeatability is evaluated only within the most consistent cohort (IFrun052–IFrun060); most other temperature/time conditions are singletons, so inference is limited to descriptive summaries. Microstructural comparisons are reported only for specimens whose image files link unambiguously to a logged thermal history; ambiguously labeled images are excluded rather than inferred.

VI. CONCLUSIONS

A bare commercial RF induction generator can be converted into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated, pyrometer-feedback annealing system with a documented, generator-agnostic modernization layer: LabVIEW/DAQ analog power control, dual-wavelength optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and an in-house machined graphite crucible/susceptor. Ported from a ~ 1970 LEPEL prototype to a current CEIA solid-state generator, the same stack demonstrated an operational power-temperature calibration ($R^2 = 0.991$ over 1200 – 1400°C in a fixed geometry), run-to-run soak repeatability of $1201.2 \pm 1.3^\circ\text{C}$ across eight nominally identical Ni4N5 anneals, and stable closed-loop soaks up to 40 h at 1325°C , with annealed-specimen microstructures (SEM/EBSD/optical) cross-referenced to their logged thermal histories. Exchanging the graphite crucible stack for a tantalum-susceptor variant extends the same furnace to non-coupling ceramic charges — sustaining 2000°C holds and reaching 2344°C before the chamber pressure interlock — demonstrated with YSZ grain growth and an empirical map of specimen/susceptor/crucible chemical compatibility at

those temperatures. Because the layer requires only a monotonic analog power-control input from the generator, the design is directly reusable by other laboratories at a small fraction of the cost of turn-key vacuum induction furnaces; complete design files, the costed bill of materials, control software, and the full run-log and characterization archives are openly available.

SUPPLEMENTARY MATERIAL

The development repository (<https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace>; archival snapshot [10.5281/zenodo.20878017](https://zenodo.org/record/20878017)) contains the complete supplementary material: the LabVIEW control VIs and MATLAB utilities, the system schematics and coil drawing, the standard operating procedure, the itemized bill of materials and design-file inventory, the 100+ raw and machine-parsed anneal logs, the SEM/EBSD and optical characterization archives with per-file catalogs, the tantalum-susceptor heat-curve workbook and high-temperature configuration survey, and the scripts that reproduce every figure and metric in this paper.

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AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflict of Interest

The authors have no conflicts to disclose. **[TODO: confirm with all authors.]**

Ethics Approval

This work did not involve human participants, human data, or animal subjects; ethics approval is not applicable.

Author Contributions

[TODO: confirm CRediT roles] — provisional: **Sterling G. Baird:** Conceptualization, Software, Investigation, Writing – original draft. **Kevin Cole:** Methodology, Resources, Supervision. Additional authors to be confirmed.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in the development repository [vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace](https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace) (<https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace>); an archival snapshot (design files, run logs, characterization data, and extracted context) is deposited at Zenodo, <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20878017>.

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